

The Beatles' appearance. This was not some insightful exec reversing Dexter's misguided rejections; rather, it was an attempt to capitalize on the demand one of the country's most popular TV shows might create. Not a change of musical heart, but simply good corporate opportunism.

How did the *Sullivan Show* go?

Notably, "*The Ed Sullivan Show* received 50,000 ticket requests for the 728-seat Studio 50 (now known as the Ed Sullivan Theater) where the band was to perform." This surpassed the previous record of 7,000 ticket requests for Elvis Presley's 1957 debut appearance on the show.^{[21](#)}

Perhaps the public was telling the experts something?

The Beatles played five songs on two segments, ending with "I Want to Hold Your Hand." Ray Bloch, Ed Sullivan's musical director, was unimpressed: "The only thing different is the hair, as far as I can see. I give them a year."

He was not alone in panning the appearance. Seawright collected a string of headlines and reviews that have not aged particularly well:

The New York Herald Tribune: "BEATLES BOMB ON TV."

The Boston Globe: "Don't let the Beatles bother you. If you don't think about them they will go away and in a few more years they will probably be bald."

The New York Times: "The Beatles' vocal quality can be described as hoarsely incoherent, with the minimal enunciation necessary to communicate the schematic texts."

The Los Angeles Times: "Not even their mothers would claim that they sing well."

The New York Herald Tribune: "75 percent publicity, 20 percent haircut and 5 percent lilting lament."

Talk about "nobody knows anything."^{[22](#)}

It wasn't just that the reviews missed the mark. What is noteworthy is how